A Medal for Willie

By William Branch

INTRODUCTION

Mrs. Jackson is the mother of a Black American soldier killed in action while fighting in the Vietnam War. The stage of the auditorium of a Black high school in a Southern town following the presentation to Mrs. Jackson of her son's medal for bravery by a three-star general from Washington and local White officials. She has changed her mind and tries to give the medal back. They ask her why . . . A Medal for Willie by William Branch.

MRS JACKSON: Why? All right then. I'll tell you why. You asked me. Now I'm gonna tell you [She begins quietly and builds in intensity, a tower of strength and emotion.] I didn't want to go through with this program an' all, to begin with. But standin' here just now, readin' off them words, I knew I just can't! I can't be that much of a hypocrite, not even for Willie. You all 'spect me to 'cept this medal and read that speech you had all ready for me, say, "Thank you kindly, suhs," and then go home an' be happy about the whole thing. But I can't! I can't go through with this, this big LIE.

Yes, I said a lie. What has all your fine talk ever meant to Willie. He walked around this town nearly all his young life and nobody cared. You Jim-Crowed him and shunned him and you shoved him off in a corner. You gave him a third-rate schoolin' and when he wasn't quiet like a mouse, you put him out in the street. You looked down on him and kept him down 'cause he was black and

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poor and didn't know no better than to believe that was the way things is supposed to be!

Yes, my Willie was dumb in a lotta ways. He didn't know nothin' 'bout no I-de-lol-logies or whatever you calls it. He wasn't fightin' 'cause he hated anybody. He joined the Army 'cause he couldn't get a decent job here. Willie thought if he did what they told him in the Army and he didn't get in no trouble, maybe someday he could come back home and walk down the street and be somebody. Willie tried so hard, he got himself killed. But he didn't know. 'Cause even while you-all's here supposed to be honorin' Willie, you keep talkin' 'bout keepin' things the way they always is. Willie didn't want things to stay the way they is. 'Cause it always meant he come out holdin' the short end of the stick - the Jim Crow end, the poor folks end.

That's why this is all such a big lie. You-all here ain't really honorin' Willie. You here tryin' to tell yourself that you been right all along. That the way you been doin' things is perfectly okay 'cause you can get boys like Willie to go out and fight and die for you and never know the difference. And you tryin' to use me and my dead boys' memory to make out like everybody's all satisfied here in the land of the free, that we's all one big happy family. Who's just tickled to death with the American Way!

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Well, I don't know nothin' 'bout no other kinda way. I ain't never been on no trips to Europe or Russia or China or any of them places that I hears the man talk about on the radio, and I don't know what they does anywhere else. But I do know a whole lot 'bout right here from my whole life of experience. And I say I don't like everything the way it is! And it's high time - way past time that a lot more changes were made! So that folks like my boy and your boy will have the same chance as anybody else to grow up and enjoy life and live like decent fold without no holdbacks 'cause they're colored.

Yes, Willie's dead and gone now, and I'm proud he was brave and helped save somebody else 'fore he got killed. But I can't help thinkin' Willie died fightin' in the wrong place.

[Quietly intense] Willie should had that machine gun over here!

So you can take this medal back on up to Washington and tell them I don't want it! Take it back. Pin it on your own shirt! Five it to the ones who keeps this big lie goin' and send boys like my Willie all over the world to die for some kinda freedom and democracy they always gets the leavin's of! You done a pretty good job. You had folks fooled a long time with all this honey-talk, an' you even had me readin' off your words for you. But I done woke up! I knows what you're tryin' to do and I ain't gonna let you

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do it to me no more! Here! Take it back! [She hurls the medal at the General.]

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AWARDS

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